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Bluetooth has finally arrived...

Bluetooth, a short-range wireless technology was unveiled in 1998. It was named after the Danish king Harald Bluetooth, who is reported to have united Denmark and Norway. He was also supposed to unite the world of consumer electronics and computers, and make all the devices in the living room, as well as the office, talk to each other. Bluetooth is widely promoted as a 'cable replacement' solution which works within 10m to 100m at 720 Kbps. But we didn't see much happening in 2001 and 2002 in this direction. The reasons are various: from Microsoft not including Bluetooth in Windows XP and its SP1, to companies trying to push customised Bluetooth devices which won't see and communicate with Bluetooth devices made by other companies. Also, a lot of other technologies such as cordless phones, Wi-Fi and microwave ovens share the same 2.4 GHz band, and hamper the performance of Bluetooth devices that are in their vicinity. Meanwhile, a lot of marketing muscle was deployed to the competing Wi-Fi standard. During this period, Ericsson—the inventor of Bluetooth—kept releasing Bluetooth-capable mobile phones under its new corporate brand Sony Ericsson. We also saw the occasional release of a Bluetooth-capable PDA from Palm, the Clie from Sony and the iPAQ from HP. But all these catered to the high-end segments, and were not really meant for the budget-conscious employee or home user.

All of this changed slowly this year. We saw a flurry of Bluetooth products announced in the last 4 months by HP, Lexus, Nextlink, Plantronics, Jabra, Sony-Ericsson, Siemens, Nokia, Palm, Microsoft, Logitech and Sony. Lexus announced a Bluetooth-integrated car which will pair with four different Bluetooth mobiles, and let you use all the mobile functionality from the dashboard and steering wheel, while your phone sits in your bag. It will allow you to dial only selected numbers from the address book while car is in motion, and all the numbers when the car is stationary. Nokia announced a Bluetooth car kit for those of us who can't buy a Lexus.

Microsoft and Logitech have a keyboard and optical mouse that will use a Bluetooth

USB dongle on the back of a PC. HP now uses Bluetooth as a standard on most of its Windows Mobile 2003-run iPAQ PDAs, but Wi-Fi is offered only on its top-of-the-line 5500 series. Tapwave released the Zodiac gaming device based on PalmOS, which uses Bluetooth. Philips introduced the world's cheapest Bluetooth-enabled GPRS colour phone—the Fidio 826—at Rs 7,500 in India last month, and it was sold out in matter of days.

My Bluetooth phone synchronizes the address book, calendar, etc, with my PC, which is in the next room. The best part is that Bluetooth is driver independent—I don't need drivers for every Bluetooth device talking to my Windows XP PC. So, when I recently bought a Siemens S55 phone, I didn't need to install a CD containing the drivers and software, as my Bluetooth-enabled PC was more than ready to talk and synchronize with any Bluetooth phone.

Since October 2003, more than 1 million Bluetooth devices are being shipped every week, all around the world. Already, 100 million Bluetooth devices have been shipped.

Bluetooth 1.2 is expected to resolve a lot of issues with the present Bluetooth 1.1 standard. It will use a frequency hopping algorithm, so that communication will not be disrupted by other devices using the same frequency. You'll also see improvement in sound and data transmission capability once Bluetooth 1.2 devices hit the stores. All these devices will be backward compatible with existing Bluetooth 1.1 devices.

Using Bluetooth to make a PC, mobile and PDA talk to each other was the most obvious use, but now we're going to see many innovative applications such as reading the temperature, opening garage doors, printing TV listings via a neighbouring printer, or a refrigerator alerting us of a power failure. It could also make for Bluetooth-enabled credit card terminals to be used by hawkers that will be connected to a mobile phone.

Bluetooth is going to make its mark in Asia more than anywhere else in world, due to smaller homes where every device is within ten metres of anything else. ■

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